

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Satire

DIRECTOR

Federico Fellini

WRITERS

Federico Fellini, Ennio
Flaiano, Tullio Pinelli,
Brunello Rondi, Pier
Paolo Pasolini

STARS

Marcello Mastroianni,
Anita Ekberg, Anouk
Aimée, Yvonne Furneaux

BEFORE

1945 Fellini cowrites *Rome, Open City*, Roberto Rossellini's gritty Nazi-occupation drama.

1958 Marcello Mastroianni gets his big break in the stylish crime-comedy *Big Deal on Madonna Street*.

AFTER

1963 Fellini's autobiographical comedy-drama *8½* follows a director (played by Mastroianni) suffering from writer's block.

In April 1953, the partially clad body of a young woman was discovered on a beach near Rome. Had Wilma Montesi accidentally drowned or committed suicide, or had she been murdered? The police investigated, and so did Italy's rapacious media. Gossip and conspiracy theories snowballed into a national scandal as the corrupt, hedonistic underworld of postwar Rome was illuminated by the flash bulbs of the city's paparazzi. Politicians, movie stars, gangsters, artists, prostitutes, fading aristocrats—they were living *la dolce vita*, "the sweet life," a whirl of drugs, orgies, and general depravity that had spun tragically out of control.

La Dolce Vita became the title of Federico Fellini's satire of this turbulent period in the history of his beloved Rome. The movie contains a veiled reference to the Montesi affair in its closing scene, when a group of characters emerge from a beach-house orgy to find a dead manta ray washed up on the shore, a metaphoric reference to Wilma Montesi. They gather around the corpse in the dawn light, the sea monster's eye staring back accusingly at them.



The movie poster casts Marcello Mastroianni as a paparazzo in the shady underworld, searching for light in the form of his perfect Eve.

It's a chilling image that is both grotesque and sad—the final entry in Fellini's catalogue of lost souls.

Seven sins

La Dolce Vita was released seven years after the death of Wilma Montesi. It takes place on the seven hills of Rome, its narrative divided into seven nights and



Federico Fellini Director

Born in Rimini, Italy, in 1920, Federico Fellini moved to Rome when he was 19 years old. He went to study law, and stayed to make movies that would immortalize the city. His early adventures as a reporter and gossip columnist exposed him to the world of show business, and in 1944 he became the apprentice of famed director Roberto Rossellini. In the 1950s, Fellini made movies of his own, and established himself as one of Italy's most controversial artists.

Fellini's work combines baroque imagery with everyday city life, often depicting scenes of excess. He was fascinated with dreams and memory, and many of his later movies tipped into the realm of psychological fantasy.

Key movies

1952 *The White Sheik*
1954 *La Strada*
1960 *La Dolce Vita*
1963 *8½*